Cik naksnīnas

Latvian diction guide for singers · Traditional Latvian folk song text, as set in Ēriks Ešenvalds' Northern Lights (Ziemeļblāzma)

TEXT	IPA	TRANSLATION
Cik naksnīnas pret ziemeli	[tsik 'naksniːnas prɛt 'ziɛmɛli]	*So many nights, toward the north,*
redzēj' kāvus karojam	['rɛdzeːj 'kaːvus 'karuɔjam]	*I saw the aurora warring,*
Ē, redzēj' kāvus karojam;	[eː 'rɛdzeːj 'kaːvus 'karuɔjam]	*Eh, I saw the aurora warring;*
Karo kāvi pie debesu,	['karuɔ 'kaːvi piɛ 'dɛbɛsu]	*The aurora battles in the sky,*
vedīs karus mūs' zemē;	['vɛdiːs 'karus muːs 'zɛmeː]	*it will bring war to our land;*
Ē, vedīs karus mūs' zemē	[eː 'vɛdiːs 'karus muːs 'zɛmeː]	*Eh, it will bring war to our land.*

Coaching Notes

- **Stress** always falls on the first syllable of the word: *NAKS-nī-nas*, *KA-ruo-jam*, *DE-be-su*. Long vowels later in a word do not attract stress.
- **Vowel length matters.** *ā, ē, ī, ū* are long; plain vowels are short. When the rhythm allows, let long vowels sit (*kāvus*, *naksnīnas*, *mūs'*), and keep short vowels pure and short.
- **No vowel reduction.** Unstressed syllables keep full, clear vowels — no English schwa in *-as*, *-us*, *-am*, *-u*.
- **o = [uɔ]** in native words: *karojam* ['karuɔjam], *karo* ['karuɔ]. Start with a quick [u] glide into an open [ɔ].
- **ie = [iɛ]**, a diphthong: *ziemeli*, *pie*. Sustain the [i] and close to [ɛ] late.
- **e** varies between closed [e] and open [æ] depending on the word; the guide uses a neutral [ɛ]. Confirm with a native coach if your ensemble wants exact open/closed distinctions (e.g. *debesu* is often sung with open [æ]).
- **c = [ts]** (*Cik*). **dz = [dz]**, one consonant, not d + z (*redzēj'*). **z** is voiced (*ziemeli*, *zemē*).
- **p, t, k** are unaspirated — no puff of air after *Cik*, *kāvus*, *karus*.
- **r** is a tapped or rolled tongue-tip r, never American.
- **Apostrophes** mark folk-song elisions: *redzēj'* = *redzēju*, *mūs'* = *mūsu*. Sing them as written, with the final vowel dropped.
- **Ē** is a sung vocable with no meaning; give it a bright, open, long [eː].
- **Dialect:** *naksnīnas* is a folk form of standard *naktiņas* ("little nights").